

HARDIK PANDYA, 32

All-rounder

Picture this. You are the vice captain of the 2024 T20 World Cup-winning team and the captain, Rohit Sharma, has just retired from the format. The captaincy should naturally pass to you. Instead, the coveted cap goes elsewhere. Not only that—you are also stripped of the vice-captaincy. The selectors cite fitness concerns, but to some, the story seems murkier. Blows like these would rattle most athletes. Pandya, however, is made of sterner stuff.

Cut to two years later. Free from the labels of captain or vice-captain, Pandya settles into his role and reminds everyone why he remains one of India's most bankable all-rounders. Whether with the bat in the middle order or the ball in key spells—2/16 against Pakistan, 2/38 against England—he delivered when it mattered most. Concerns about his fitness lingered, yet Pandya bowled his full quota through the nine matches. The numbers underline his influence: nine wickets at an average of 22 plus 217 runs at a strike rate of 160.7.

HARDIK PANDYA
MATCHES: 9
RUNS: 217
HS: 52
WKTS: 9
BEST: 2/16

"This trophy was a redemption for me," he said after the final. A natural showman with a devil-may-care demeanour, Pandya's 'aura farming' was on full display during the celebrations. With his girlfriend Mahieka by his side, he struck his trademark pose: a shrug, both hands raised with the trophy. At 32, he insists more silverware lies ahead. "I am a senior player, but only halfway through my career.... I would like to win at least 10 more trophies with Team India and [in the] IPL. At least five to six should come." Slightly cocky, perhaps—but it wouldn't be Pandya any other way. **—SS**

ISHAN KISHAN, 27

Wicketkeeper-batsman

Two years ago, Ishan Kishan appeared to have drifted out of India's cricketing plans. The wicketkeeper-batter fell out of favour after withdrawing from India's 2023 tour of South Africa, citing personal reasons and mental fatigue. He was even removed from the BCCI's central contracts for 2023–24. For a player who had once scored a breathtaking ODI double century, the fall was vertiginous. Allegations followed about Kishan not showing sufficient commitment towards domestic cricket. The road back was long. It took two-and-a-half years, a mountain of domestic runs and a standout Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy campaign just before the T20 World Cup selections for Kishan to force his way back into contention. Kishan began the New Zealand T20I series before the WC strongly and later moved to No. 3 as team combinations shifted. He scored 215 runs and finished second among top run-getters there.

The redemption arc reached its peak at the World Cup. His defining moment came against Pakistan in Colombo, where his blistering 77 off 40 balls powered India to a 61-run victory. Kishan finished the tournament with 317 runs—the fourth-highest.

The innings Kishan played in the final was coloured with emotion. On its eve, he received some devastating news—a close cousin had died in a car accident. Kishan kept his composure, walked out to bat and smashed 54 off 25 balls. Later, he revealed the motivation: "She always wanted me to score big runs...rather than letting emotions take over, I thought the best thing I could do was score runs for her."

From being stripped of his central contract to returning as a leading performer in a World Cup, Kishan's journey underscores a simple truth: careers in sport, like life itself, are rarely linear. There are falls and doubts, but redemption is at hand for those willing to endure the grind and keep believing in their craft. Kishan's comeback is a reminder that setbacks do not define an athlete – the response to them does.

—Amitabh Srivastava

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All stats are for the 2026 ICC T20 WC; HS=Highest Score; S/R=Strike Rate; Wkts=Wickets; Best=Best Bowling Figures; Eco=Economy